SQL FOR DATA ANALYSIS · LESSON 2 OF 15

ER Diagrams, Relationships, Keys & Normalisation

Design databases the way professionals do. Draw ER diagrams, read crow's-foot notation, model one-to-one, one-to-many and many-to-many relationships, master every type of key (super, candidate, primary, alternate, composite, foreign, surrogate) and normalise tables to 3NF.

SQL class 1 · 2026 · Beginner · 110 min

By the end of this lesson you can

- Read and draw an ER diagram with entities, attributes and relationships
- Identify 1:1, 1:N and M:N relationships and resolve M:N with a junction table
- Define super, candidate, primary, alternate, composite, foreign, surrogate and unique keys, with examples
- Explain referential integrity and what happens on delete/update of a parent row
- Normalise a flat table into 1NF, 2NF and 3NF, and know when to denormalise

Datasets used

`superstore_sales.csv`

Why design matters

A database that is designed badly is slow, wastes space and, worst of all, lets data contradict itself. Imagine the customer's city stored in every order row: if the customer moves, you must update thousands of rows, and missing one creates two different "truths". Good design stores **each fact once** and connects tables with **keys**.

Entity–Relationship (ER) diagrams

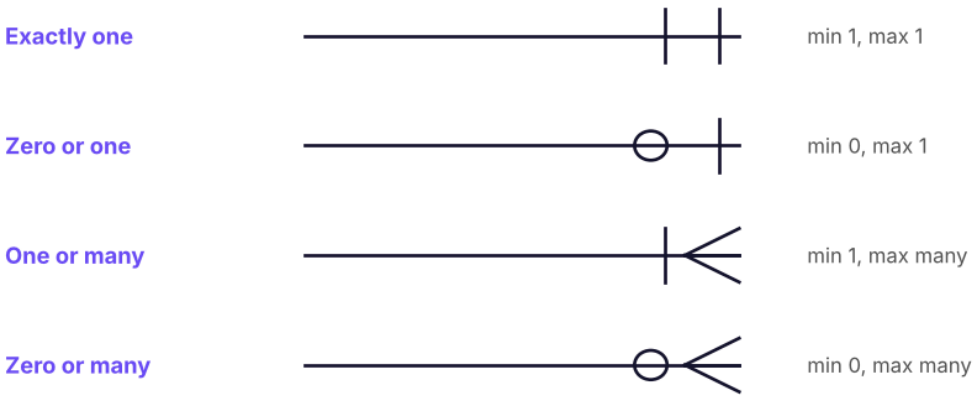
An **ER diagram** is a picture of the data model before any table is created.

DEFINITION **Building blocks**

Entity: a real-world thing you store data about: Customer, Order, Product, Employee. Becomes a **table**. **Attribute**: a property of an entity: name, city, price. Becomes a **column**. **Relationship**: how entities are associated: a Customer *places* Orders. Implemented with **foreign keys**. **Cardinality**: how many of one entity relate to another: one-to-one, one-to-many, many-to-many. **Participation (optionality)**: whether the relationship is mandatory (every order must have a customer) or optional (a customer may have zero orders).

Crow's-foot notation

The most common notation in industry draws symbols at the ends of each relationship line:



Crow's-foot symbols. Read each end as "minimum ... maximum".

Reading example: Customer `||—o<` Order means "each order belongs to **exactly one** customer; each customer places **zero or many** orders".

Types of relationships

One-to-one (1:1)

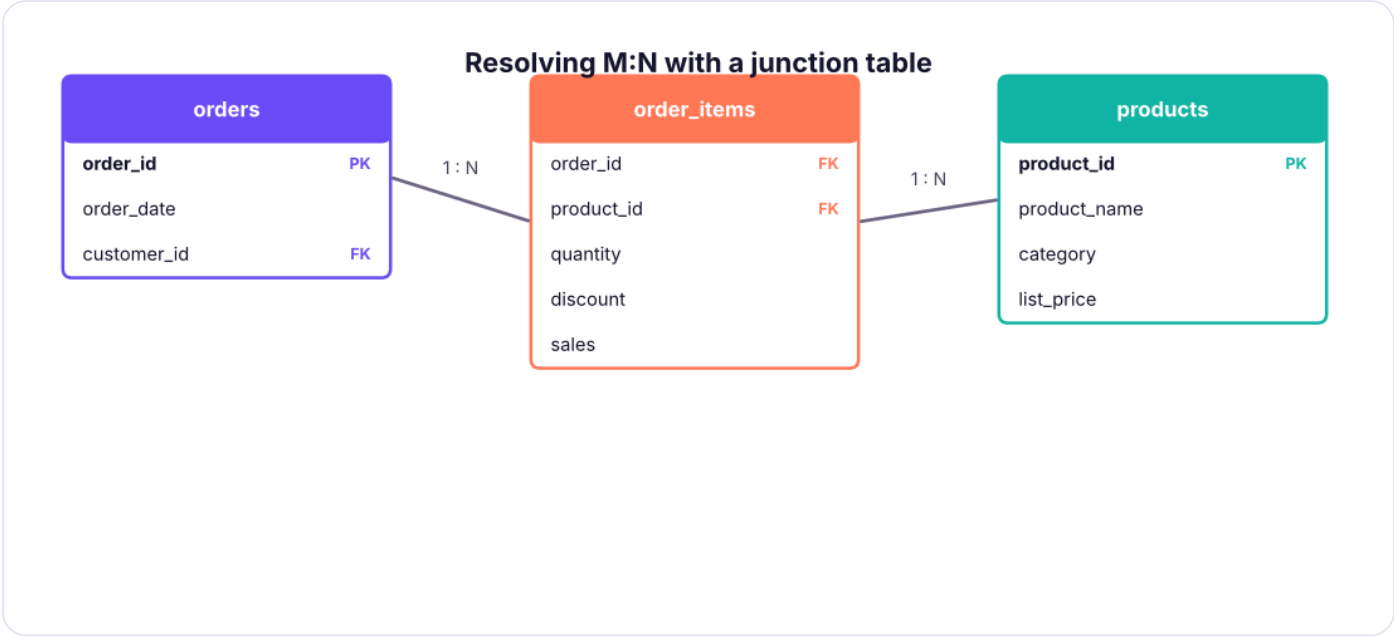
Each row in A matches at most one row in B. Example: Employee ↔ Employee_Bank_Details. Often used to split sensitive or rarely used columns into a separate, more protected table. Implemented with a foreign key that is also **unique** (often the same as the primary key).

One-to-many (1:N) — the most common

One row in A matches many rows in B; each B row matches one A row. Examples: Customer → Orders, Department → Employees, Category → Products. The **foreign key goes on the "many" side** (`orders.customer_id`).

Many-to-many (M:N)

Many rows in A match many in B: Students ↔ Courses, Orders ↔ Products, Actors ↔ Movies. Relational tables cannot store this directly, so we add a **junction (bridge, associative) table** that holds a pair of foreign keys, turning one M:N into two 1:N relationships.



An order contains many products and a product appears in many orders. The junction table order_items resolves the many-to-many relationship and stores facts about each pair (quantity, discount).

Relationship	Example	Where the foreign key goes
1 : 1	Employee – Passport	Either side, marked UNIQUE
1 : N	Department – Employees	On the N side (`employees.dept_id`)
M : N	Students – Courses	In a junction table `enrolments(student_id, course_id)`
Self (recursive)	Employee – Manager	In the same table: `employees.manager_id` → `employees.emp_id`

Let's check the real cardinalities in our retail data with SQL. How many orders does each customer have, and how many items does each order have?

SQL

```sql
SELECT MIN(n_orders) AS min_orders_per_customer,
       MAX(n_orders) AS max_orders_per_customer,
       ROUND(AVG(n_orders * 1.0), 2) AS avg_orders_per_customer
FROM (SELECT customer_id, COUNT(*) AS n_orders FROM orders GROUP BY customer_id) AS t;
```

RESULT

min_orders_per_customer	max_orders_per_customer	avg_orders_per_customer
1	10	4.08

1 rows × 3 columns

SQL

```sql
SELECT items_in_order, COUNT(*) AS number_of_orders
FROM (SELECT order_id, COUNT(*) AS items_in_order FROM order_items GROUP BY order_id) AS t
GROUP BY items_in_order
ORDER BY items_in_order;
```

RESULT

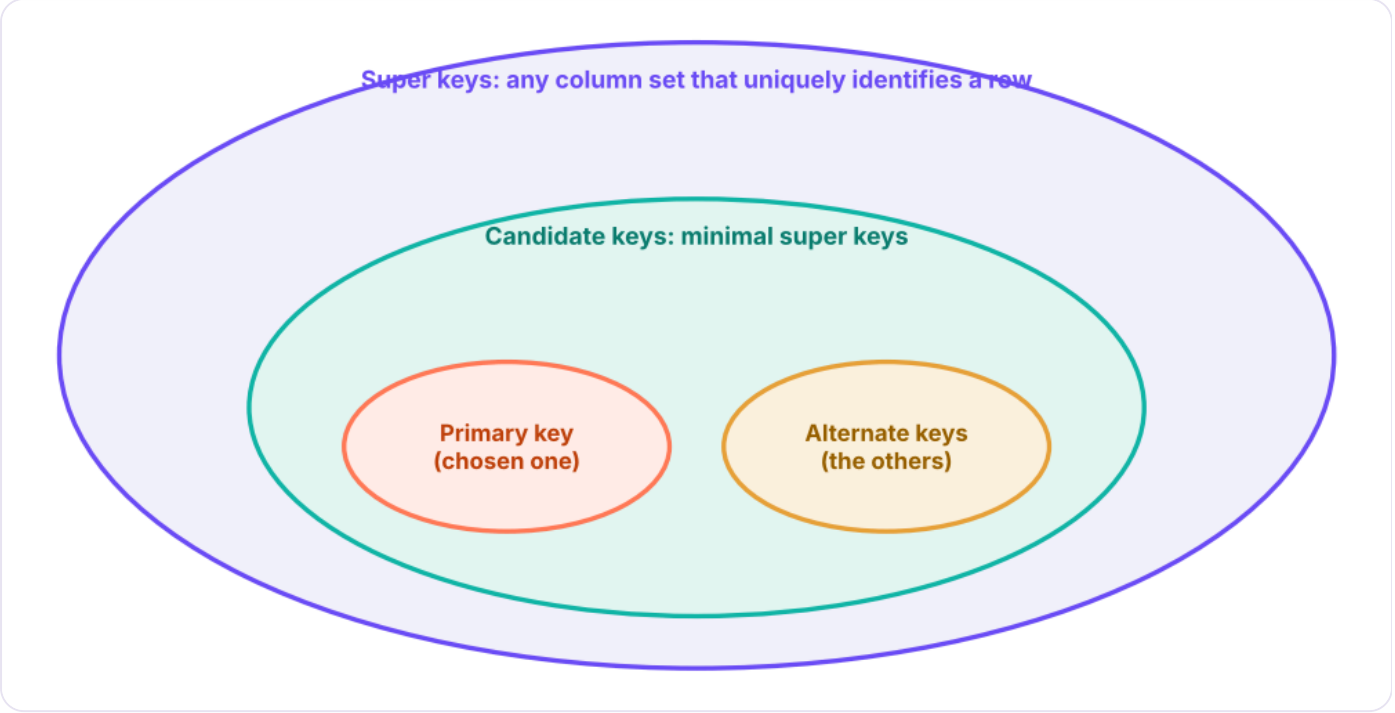
items_in_order	number_of_orders
1	1394
2	920
3	455
4	431

4 rows × 2 columns

So Customer → Orders is 1:N, and Order → Order items is 1:N (1 to 4 items per order here).

Keys

Keys are columns (or sets of columns) with special meaning. They are among the most frequently asked interview topics.



How the main key types relate: every candidate key is a minimal super key; one candidate is chosen as the primary key and the rest become alternate keys.

Example table `employees(emp_id, email, pan_number, name, dept_id, phone)`, where `emp_id`, `email` and `pan_number` are each unique:

Key type	Definition	Example
Super key	Any set of columns that uniquely identifies a row (may include extra columns)	`{emp_id}`, `{emp_id, name}`, `{email, dept_id}`
Candidate key	A **minimal** super key: remove any column and it stops being unique	`{emp_id}`, `{email}`, `{pan_number}`
Primary key (PK)	The candidate key chosen to identify rows. Unique, **not NULL**, one per table	`emp_id`
Alternate key	Candidate keys not chosen as primary; enforce them with `UNIQUE`	`email`, `pan_number`
Composite key	A key made of two or more columns	`(order_id, product_id)` in order_items; `(student_id, course_id)` in enrolments
Foreign key (FK)	A column that refers to a PK (or unique key) in another table	`employees.dept_id` → `departments.dept_id`
Unique key	A UNIQUE constraint: no duplicates, but (in SQL Server) one NULL is allowed	`phone`
Surrogate key	An artificial key with no business meaning, often an auto-number	`customer_key INT IDENTITY(1,1)`
Natural key	A key with business meaning	PAN number, GSTIN, ISBN, email

> **TIP** **Surrogate or natural?**
>
> Natural keys can change (people change email, products get recoded) and can be long. Most warehouses and Power BI models use **surrogate integer keys** for joins, and keep natural keys as alternate (unique) keys.

Primary key vs unique key

	Primary key	Unique key
Duplicates allowed	No	No
NULL allowed	No	Yes (SQL Server allows one NULL; PostgreSQL allows many)
Per table	Exactly one	Many
Default index (SQL Server)	Clustered	Non-clustered

Referential integrity

A foreign key guarantees that every child row points to a parent that exists: you cannot insert an order for customer `C9999` if that customer does not exist. What happens when a **parent** row is deleted or its key is updated is controlled by the FK's actions:

Action	On DELETE of the parent	Use when
`NO ACTION` (default)	The delete is blocked if children exist	Most business data
`CASCADE`	Children are deleted too	Order → order items
`SET NULL`	Children's FK becomes NULL	Employee → manager who leaves
`SET DEFAULT`	Children get the column's default	Rare

```sql
CREATE TABLE departments (
    dept_id   INT PRIMARY KEY,
    dept_name VARCHAR(50) NOT NULL UNIQUE
);
CREATE TABLE employees (
    emp_id     INT PRIMARY KEY,
    email      VARCHAR(100) NOT NULL UNIQUE,          -- alternate key
    name       VARCHAR(100) NOT NULL,
    dept_id    INT NOT NULL REFERENCES departments(dept_id),   -- foreign key
    manager_id INT NULL REFERENCES employees(emp_id)           -- self-referencing FK
);
```

Lesson 4 shows these constraints in action.

Normalisation

Normalisation organises columns and tables to reduce redundancy and avoid **anomalies**:

- **Update anomaly**: the same fact stored in many rows gets changed in some but not others.
- **Insert anomaly**: you cannot add a fact without another fact (cannot add a new product until someone orders it).
- **Delete anomaly**: deleting one fact removes another (deleting the only order of a product deletes the product's information).

Start with the flat Superstore file, which repeats customer and product details on every order line:

```sql
SELECT TOP 5 order_id, order_date, customer_id, customer_name, city, product_id,
product_name, category, quantity, sales
FROM superstore;
```

RESULT

order_id	order_date	customer_id	customer_name	city	product_id	product_n
IN-2023-00001	2023-01-01	C0765	Ishaan Gupta	Bengaluru	P0059	Nova Pho 223
IN-2023-00001	2023-01-01	C0765	Ishaan Gupta	Bengaluru	P0050	Orbit Appliance
IN-2023-00001	2023-01-01	C0765	Ishaan Gupta	Bengaluru	P0011	Orbit Tabl 248
IN-2023-00002	2023-01-03	C0791	Kabir Singh	Ahmedabad	P0037	Crest Stor 946
IN-2023-00003	2023-01-03	C0049	Sneha Khan	Ahmedabad	P0018	Crest Bookcase

5 rows × 10 columns

First normal form (1NF)

- Each cell holds **one atomic value** (no lists like `"Chair, Table"`).
- No repeating groups of columns (`product1`, `product2`, `product3`).
- Each row is unique (a key exists).

The flat file is already in 1NF: one product per row, and every row has a unique `row_id`. The natural key would be `(order_id, product_id)`, but 70 lines repeat the same product within the same order, which is exactly why real systems add a surrogate key such as `row_id` or `item_id`.

Second normal form (2NF)

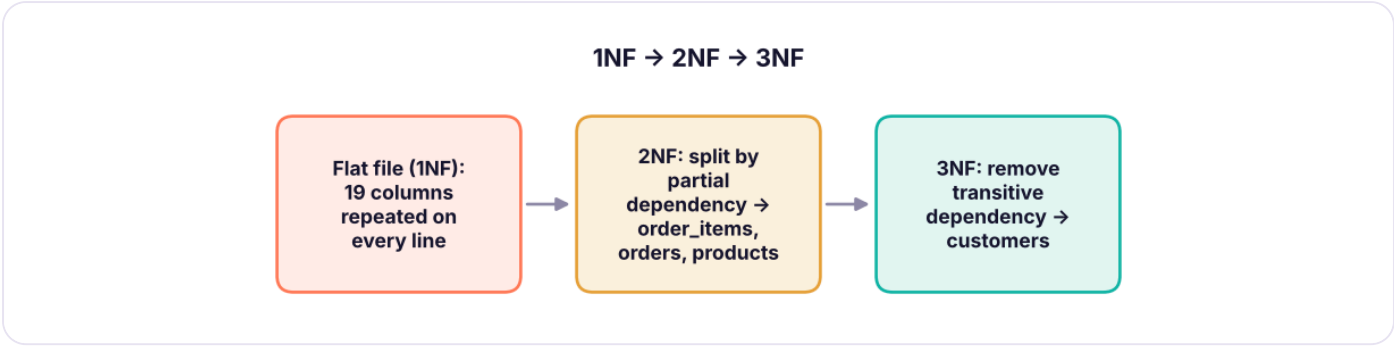
1NF **and** every non-key column depends on the **whole** key, not part of it (this matters only with composite keys). With key `(order_id, product_id)`:

- `quantity`, `discount`, `sales` depend on both: they stay.
- `order_date`, `customer_id`, `ship_mode` depend only on `order_id` → move to an `orders` table.
- `product_name`, `category` depend only on `product_id` → move to a `products` table.

Third normal form (3NF)

2NF **and** no **transitive** dependency: non-key columns must depend only on the key, not on other non-key columns. In `orders`, `customer_name`, `city` and `region` depend on `customer_id`, not on `order_id` → move them to a `customers` table.

> "Every non-key attribute must provide a fact about the key, the whole key, and nothing but the key." (Bill Kent)



Normalising the flat Superstore file to 3NF gives the four-table RetailDB design.

How much repetition did normalisation remove? Count the distinct customers and products versus rows:

```sql
SELECT COUNT(*)                   AS order_lines,
       COUNT(DISTINCT order_id)     AS orders,
       COUNT(DISTINCT customer_id)  AS customers,
       COUNT(DISTINCT product_id)   AS products
FROM superstore;
```

RESULT

order_lines	orders	customers	products
6323	3200	785	78

1 rows × 4 columns

The flat file stores customer details 6,323 times; the normalised design stores them once per customer (fewer than 800 rows).

Normal form	Rule in plain words
1NF	One value per cell; no repeating columns; a key exists
2NF	No column depends on only part of a composite key
3NF	No column depends on another non-key column
BCNF	Every determinant is a candidate key (stricter 3NF)
4NF / 5NF	Remove multi-valued and join dependencies (rare in practice)

Denormalisation and the star schema

Transactional systems (OLTP) are normalised for safe, fast writes. Analytical systems (OLAP, data warehouses, Power BI) are often **denormalised** into a **star schema**: one central **fact table** (sales events with numbers) surrounded by **dimension tables** (customer, product, date, region) to make reading and aggregating fast and simple. You will build one in the Power BI track (Lesson 3).

	OLTP (normalised)	OLAP / warehouse (star schema)
Purpose	Run the business: place orders, update stock	Analyse the business
Operations	Many small inserts and updates	Large reads and aggregations
Design	3NF, many tables	Fact + dimension tables
Examples	App database in SQL Server/PostgreSQL	Snowflake, BigQuery, Fabric, Power BI model

Summary

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- ER diagrams show **entities** (tables), **attributes** (columns) and **relationships** with **cardinality** (1:1, 1:N, M:N).
- The foreign key sits on the **many** side; M:N needs a **junction table** with a composite key.
- Super key ⊇ candidate keys (minimal); one candidate becomes the **primary key** (unique, not NULL), the others are **alternate keys** (UNIQUE).
- Composite keys combine columns; surrogate keys are artificial integers; natural keys carry business meaning.
- Foreign keys enforce **referential integrity**; ON DELETE CASCADE / SET NULL / NO ACTION decide what happens to children.
- Normalise to **3NF** to remove redundancy and anomalies; denormalise into a **star schema** for analytics.

Quick quiz

6 questions · tap an answer to check it

1. Students can enrol in many courses and courses have many students. How do you model this?

- **A** Put course_id in the students table
- **B** Put student_id in the courses table
- **C** Create a junction table enrolments(student_id, course_id)
- **D** Use one table with a column per course

Answer: C. A junction table resolves M:N into two 1:N relationships.

2. In a 1:N relationship between departments and employees, where does the foreign key go?

- **A** In departments
- **B** In employees
- **C** In both tables
- **D** In a third table

Answer: B. The FK goes on the "many" side: employees.dept_id.

3. Which statement about a primary key is FALSE?

A It must be unique

B It cannot be NULL

C A table can have several primary keys

D It can consist of more than one column

Answer: C. A table has one primary key, which may be composite.

4. `email` is unique in the employees table but `emp_id` was chosen as the primary key. What is email?

A A foreign key

B An alternate (candidate) key

C A surrogate key

D A super key only

Answer: B. Unchosen candidate keys are alternate keys, enforced with UNIQUE.

5. In `orders(order_id, customer_id, customer_city)`, customer_city depends on customer_id. Which normal form is violated?

A 1NF

B 2NF

C 3NF

D None

Answer: C. A non-key column depending on another non-key column is a transitive dependency, violating 3NF.

6. What does ON DELETE CASCADE on order_items.order_id do?

A Deleting an order also deletes its order items

B Deleting an order is blocked if it has items

C Order items get a NULL order_id

D Nothing

Answer: A. CASCADE propagates the delete to child rows.

EXERCISE **Design a library database**

A library has members, books and loans. A member can borrow many books over time; a book (copy) can be borrowed many times; each loan has a borrow date, due date and return date. Books have an ISBN, title and author; authors can write many books and a book can have several authors. Draw the entities, keys and relationships.

Show solution (worked answer)

- `members(member_id PK, name, email UNIQUE, phone)`
- `books(book_id PK, isbn UNIQUE, title, publisher, year)`
- `authors(author_id PK, name)`
- `book_authors(book_id FK, author_id FK, PRIMARY KEY (book_id, author_id))`: junction for M:N.
- `copies(copy_id PK, book_id FK, shelf)`: one book has many physical copies.
- `loans(loan_id PK, copy_id FK, member_id FK, borrow_date, due_date, return_date NULL)`. Relationships: members 1:N loans; copies 1:N loans; books 1:N copies; books M:N authors (via book_authors).

INTERVIEW CORNER

Questions you may be asked

Q: Difference between primary key, unique key and foreign key? PK uniquely identifies rows, no NULLs, one per table. A unique key also prevents duplicates but allows a NULL (one in SQL Server) and a table can have many. A foreign key references a PK/unique key in another table to enforce relationships.

Q: What is a candidate key? A composite key? A candidate key is a minimal set of columns that uniquely identifies rows; one is chosen as the PK. A composite key uses two or more columns together, such as (order_id, product_id).

Q: What is normalisation and why denormalise? Normalisation removes redundancy and anomalies (1NF–3NF). Data warehouses denormalise into star schemas to make analytical queries simpler and faster.

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